UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA, LOS ANGELES UCLA

BERKELEY · DAVIS · IRVINE · LOS ANGELES · RIVERSIDE · SAN DIEGO · SAN FRANCISCO SANTA BARBARA · SANTA CRUZ

Phone: (310) 825-5346
Fax: (310) 206-4038
Email: kaner@chem.ucla.edu

RICHARD B. KANER
DEPARTMENT OF CHEMISTRY AND BIOCHEMISTRY
P.O. Box 951569
607 Charles E. Young Drive, East
LOS ANGELES, CALIFORNIA 90095-1569

January 12, 2026

Dear Selection Committee,

I take great pleasure in recommending Min Kyu Lee for the UCLA Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award. As Min's faculty advisor, I am well aware of his exceptional commitment to undergraduate education, mentorship, and instructional service across UCLA. I have followed his teaching contributions closely through his extensive involvement in instructional programs, outreach activities, and his demonstrated impact on undergraduate students.

Min has served as a teaching assistant across a wide range of instructional roles, including general and organic chemistry laboratory courses, developmental biology laboratories, undergraduate enrichment programs, and campus-wide instructional support initiatives. Across these settings, Min has consistently demonstrated professionalism, dedication, and a strong student-centered approach. He is deeply committed to helping students understand not only course material, but also what it means to engage meaningfully with science as a discipline.

Min's dedication to undergraduate education extends beyond his assigned teaching responsibilities. Notably, Min regularly volunteers his time to give laboratory tours to undergraduate students who are unable to join research labs due to space or capacity limitations. He offers these tours during his spare time, outside of his formal TA and research duties, to help students gain a realistic and welcoming understanding of what a chemistry research laboratory is like. These tours provide students, many of whom are early in their academic careers, with valuable exposure to laboratory culture, instrumentation, and the day-to-day practice of scientific research. This effort reflects Min's genuine commitment to broadening access to scientific learning opportunities and mentoring students even when formal pathways are unavailable.

Min has also been actively involved in programs that support student success and equity in STEM. He has served as a facilitator for the Program for Excellence in Education and Research in Science (PEERS), where he worked closely with undergraduates navigating challenging coursework through collaborative learning and mentorship. Additionally, Min served as a laboratory instructor for the Biomedical Science Enrichment Program (BISEP), an intensive summer program designed to prepare undergraduates for future research careers. In these roles, Min has demonstrated a strong ability to support students from diverse backgrounds and help them build confidence, academic skills, and a sense of belonging within the field of science.

In addition, Min worked as a Graduate Teaching and Learning Assistant with UCLA's Bruin Learn Center of Excellence, where he supported instructors and teaching assistants in effectively using the campus learning management system. This role reflects Min's interest in improving instructional quality at the institutional level by providing understanding, clarity, and effective communication in student learning.

What distinguishes Min is not only the various teaching roles he has held, but also the initiative he takes to support students beyond formal expectations. His willingness to dedicate personal time to mentoring, outreach, and educational access speaks to his character and commitment as an educator.

Based on his sustained contributions to undergraduate education, mentorship, and instructional excellence across UCLA, I give Min Kyu Lee my strongest recommendation for the Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award.

Sincerely,

Richard B. Kaner

Richard B. Kaner
Distinguished Professor of Chemistry
Distinguished Professor of Materials Science & Engineering
Dr. Myung Ki Hong Endowed Chair in Materials Innovation
UCLA

Nominee Statement

As a third-year teaching assistant at UCLA, I have dedicated my teaching to advancing student learning, equity, and engagement across a wide range of instructional settings. My experiences span laboratory instruction, collaborative learning facilitation, summer enrichment programs, and instructional technology support. Across each role, I have focused on creating inclusive learning environments that emphasize conceptual understanding, confidence-building, and collaborative learning.

From the 2022–2023 academic year through Summer Quarter, I served as a teaching assistant for general and organic chemistry laboratory courses. These courses often represent students' first sustained exposure to experimental science and include learners with highly varied academic preparation. To support meaningful learning, I structured laboratory sections around clarity, approachability, and active engagement [1]. I provided clarifying explanations for the pre-lab discussions to emphasize the purpose of each experiment and its real-world relevance, rather than procedural memorization. During lab sessions, I prioritized guided questioning and real-time feedback, helping students interpret results, troubleshoot experiments, and connect observations to core scientific principles. As a result, students demonstrated improved confidence in laboratory work and greater independence in data analysis over the course of the quarter, as reflected in lab performance and course feedback.

To further support undergraduate success, I served as a facilitator in the Program for Excellence in Education and Research in Science (PEERS) through the Undergraduate Research Center – Physical Sciences. In this role, I worked closely with students navigating challenging STEM coursework, specifically organic chemistry, many of whom faced systemic or academic barriers to success [2]. I implemented collaborative learning strategies that emphasized peer discussion, accountability, and constructive feedback. Rather than focusing on content delivery, I guided students to articulate their reasoning, identify misconceptions, and develop effective study strategies. At the end of each session, students' confidence in problem-solving and a stronger sense of belonging within STEM disciplines increased, and they overcame their fear of challenging subjects.

During Summer 2024, I served as a laboratory instructor for the Biomedical Sciences Enrichment Program (BISEP), an intensive eight-week summer program designed to prepare undergraduates for biomedical research careers. Teaching in BISEP required integrating rigorous laboratory instruction with mentorship and professional development. I supported students in developing technical skills, scientific communication abilities, and clarity about their academic and research goals. By fostering a supportive and structured learning environment, I observed significant growth in students' confidence and engagement with research. Many students left the program with a clearer vision of their future in science and increased readiness to pursue research opportunities at UCLA.

In addition to direct instruction, I worked as a Graduate Teaching and Learning Assistant (GTLA) for the Bruin Learn Center of Excellence within UCLA IT Services [3]. Additionally, this

role enhanced my ability to design accessible and well-organized digital learning environments. I supported instructors and teaching assistants in effectively using Bruin Learn, and I applied these practices in my own teaching by improving course organization, streamlining communication, and providing timely, transparent feedback. These efforts helped reduce student confusion and allowed them to focus more fully on mastering course material.

During the 2024–2025 academic year, I taught a developmental biology laboratory course outside my primary major. This experience challenged me to adapt quickly, collaborate closely with faculty, and refine my teaching strategies for a new subject area. By focusing on transferable pedagogical principles such as clarity, inclusivity, and active learning, I successfully supported students in mastering unfamiliar concepts while expanding my own instructional capability.

Currently, I am teaching organic chemistry once again, continually refining my approach based on student feedback and reflective practice. I view teaching as an evolving process and actively seek opportunities for professional growth. Across all roles, my goal has been consistent: to help students feel capable, supported, and intellectually engaged. I take pride in contributing to UCLA's teaching mission by fostering learning environments where students not only succeed academically but also develop confidence in their ability to participate in science.

Reference:

Artifact 1: Practice midterm review questions with a few step-by-step solutions. Moving forward, the step-by-step solutions were made into videos for students' convenience.

Artifact 2: Practice worksheet generated for PEERS students for the organic chemistry course CHEM 30A.

Artifact 3: Follow-up regarding offer letter and appointment for the GTLA position for the Bruin Learn Center of Excellence, UCLA IT Services

Statement of Teaching Philosophy

My teaching philosophy has been shaped by my experiences as a teaching assistant across laboratory instruction, collaborative learning programs, summer enrichment initiatives, and instructional support roles at UCLA. Through these roles, I have come to understand that teaching is not always about the delivery of information, but one that requires attentiveness to student needs, adaptability across contexts, and a sustained commitment to equity and growth. As a teaching assistant, I occupy a unique position at the intersection of instruction and mentorship, and I view this role as both a responsibility and an opportunity to meaningfully impact students' academic and personal development.

At the core of my teaching philosophy is the belief that learning flourishes when students feel supported, capable, and intellectually engaged. Many students, particularly in STEM laboratory courses, enter learning spaces with uncertainty about their abilities or anxiety about making mistakes. As a TA, I am often the most immediate point of contact for students, and I take the responsibility of shaping their day-to-day learning experience. I strive to create environments where questions are welcomed, mistakes are normalized, and curiosity is encouraged. By fostering an atmosphere of approachability and respect, I aim to reduce barriers that can prevent students from fully engaging with the material.

Clarity and structure are foundational to my teaching practice. In laboratory settings, where students must balance conceptual understanding with technical skills, unclear expectations can quickly become overwhelming. I therefore emphasize transparent communication, clearly articulated learning objectives, and consistent guidance throughout each laboratory session. I approach pre-lab discussions not as procedural briefings, but as opportunities to contextualize experiments, explain underlying principles, and connect activities to broader scientific questions. This approach helps students understand not only what they are doing, but why the work matters. Over time, I have observed that students become more confident, independent, and willing to engage critically with their results.

A defining feature of my teaching philosophy is an emphasis on conceptual understanding rather than endless memorization. As a TA, I frequently work with students who feel pressured to "get the right answer" without fully understanding the reasoning behind it. In response, I use guided questioning and real-time feedback to encourage students to articulate their thought processes, reflect on experimental outcomes, and troubleshoot challenging experiments. In lab courses, I frame experiments as opportunities to practice scientific thinking, forming hypotheses, interpreting data, and learning from unexpected results. This approach reinforces the idea that learning is a process, not a performance.

Inclusivity and equity are central to my identity as an educator. Students come to UCLA with diverse educational backgrounds, identities, and levels of preparation, and these differences shape how they experience learning environments. My work as a TA in programs such as the Program for Excellence in Education and Research in Science (PEERS) and the Biomedical Sciences Enrichment Program (BISEP) reinforced the importance of well-guided support, community-building, and representation in student success. In these settings, I saw firsthand how collaborative learning, mentorship, and validation can transform students' confidence and persistence in STEM fields. These experiences deeply influenced how I approach all of my teaching roles, prompting me to prioritize inclusivity not as an add-on, but as a core pedagogical principle.

Adaptability has also been essential to my development as a teaching assistant. Teaching across different disciplines challenged me to step outside my academic comfort zone and refine how I communicate complex ideas. As a TA, I learned that effective teaching is not defined by disciplinary expertise alone, but by the ability to listen, anticipate student difficulties, and respond thoughtfully. Teaching outside my primary field encouraged me to rely on transferable pedagogical principles such as clarity, engagement, and responsiveness, and strengthened my confidence in navigating unfamiliar instructional contexts.

My philosophy also recognizes the importance of instructional technology as a tool for supporting student learning. Through my work with the Bruin Learn Center of Excellence, I gained insight into how thoughtful course design and digital organization can significantly enhance accessibility and reduce cognitive load for students. As a TA, I apply these principles by ensuring that course materials are clearly organized, expectations are communicated consistently, and feedback is actionable. When used intentionally, instructional technology supports transparency and allows students to focus more fully on learning rather than logistics.

Reflection is a defining element of my teaching practice. I view teaching as an evolving process that benefits from continual self-assessment and constructive criticism. As a TA, I regularly reflect on student questions, patterns of misunderstanding, and informal feedback to evaluate my effectiveness. Each quarter presents new opportunities to refine my approach, experiment with strategies, and better align my teaching with student needs. This reflective practice mirrors the scientific method itself and reinforces my belief that growth, both for students and educators, occurs through a thoughtful process.

Ultimately, my goal as a teaching assistant is to help students develop confidence in their ability to learn, think critically, and participate meaningfully in academic spaces. I want students to leave my sections feeling supported, capable, and motivated to continue their educational journey. Teaching at UCLA has profoundly shaped my identity as an educator, and I am committed to contributing to the university's mission by fostering learning environments that prioritize excellence, equity, and student-centered growth.

Chem 14BL **FALL 2022**

Practice Problems for Midterm

Midterm – October 30 (Sunday)-

3:00 pm – 6:00 am ON LINE

DON'T DTART LATE – NO EXTRA TIME WILL BE GIVEN IF YOU ARE LATE TO THE EXAM

The midterm will include topics such as error analysis, solutions concentrations, Beer's Law and acid- base titration experiment.

Error Analysis

1. Calculate the percent error for the following quantities:

   (a) $[(20.54 \pm 0.02) \times (0.254 \pm 0.003)] / (3.21 \pm 0.05)$
   (b) $[(30.078 \pm 0.003) - (20.174 \pm 0.001) + (9.813 \pm 0.005)]$
   (c) $[(0.642 \pm 0.002) \times (2.413 \pm 0.004)] - (0.501 \pm 0.002)$
   (d) $[(12.635 \pm 0.005) / (5.967 \pm 0.003)] + (0.478 \pm 0.004)$

2. Calculate the absolute errors for the quantities in question 1.

3. Calculate the percent relative average deviation for the following set of data.
   20.96, 20.85, 20.89, 20.92

Concentrations

4. Define the concentration terms molarity, normality, weight percent(w/v%) , ppm

5. A phosphoric acid (H_3PO_4) solution was prepared by transferring 0.0196 g to a 1-L volumetric flask and diluting the solution to the mark. Calculate the concentration of the H_3PO_4 solution in molarity, normality, ppm, and weight percent (w/v % and w/w %)

   (Atomic mass H=1.0000 g/ mol, P = 31.00 g/mol, O = 16.00 g/mol)

6. A sodium hydroxide solution was prepared by transferring 0.4063g to a 100-mL volumetric flask and diluting the solution to the mark. A 10-mL aliquot of this solution was transferred to a 50-mL volumetric flask and the solution we diluted to the mark. Calculate the concentration of the final sodium hydroxide solution in molarity and w/v% units.

   (Atomic mass H=1.0000 g/ mol, Na = 23.00 g/mol, O = 16.00 g/mol)

7. A student made a standard solution by transferring 0.0400 g of NaCl into a 50-ml volumetric flask, dissolving the salt and diluting to the mark. She then withdrew 5-ml aliquot with a volumetric pipet and transferred to a 50 ml volumetric flask. The solution was diluted to the mark. Calculate the concentration of the **sodium in parts** per million. Assume that 1 ml = 1g.

   (Atomic mass Na = 23.00 g/ mol, Cl = 35.45 g/mol)

Practice Problems (Continued)

Beer's law

8. (a) Beer's Law is summarized by the equation: $A = \varepsilon bc$
Name and define each of the symbols in this equation.

(b) Calculate the percent transmittance of a solution if its absorbance is 0.352

9. The following set of data was obtained for the calibration curve for a Beer's Law experiment.

Molarity	***Absorbance***
blank solution	0.0
9.80 x 10-5	0.240
1.96 x 10-4	0.475
3.10 x 10-4	0.741

(a) Plot the data and calculate the slope of the line.

(b) Calculate the concentration of a solution of the same compound if its absorbance were 0.500.

Titrations

10. Which of the following molecules are acids and which one of them are bases?

HCl, C_6H_5COOH, NH_4Cl, H_2CO_3, CH_3NH_2

11 Write the chemical reaction with base (OH^-) for those molecules that you identified as acids in question #10. Write the formula of the conjugate bases for these molecules.

12 Write the chemical reaction with acid (H^+) for those molecules that you identified as bases in question #10. Write the formula of the conjugate acids for these molecules.

13. Suppose you have a 50.00ml of 0.0100 M chloroacetic acid solution, $HC_2H_2O_2Cl$.
$K_a = 1.40X10^{-3}$.

(a) What is the initial pH for this solution?

(b) What is the equivalence point pH if the chloroacetic acid was titrated with 0.0100M NaOH?

14. (a) Calculate the molarity of the standard base solution if a 5.1362 g sample is used to prepare 100 ml in the volumetric flask. (Molecular Weight – 121.13g).

(b) Calculate the Molar concentration of an acid solution, if 20.74 ml were required to titrate a 10.00-ml aliquot of the solution prepared in 14.

Practice Problems (Continued)

15. Calculate the pH of each of the following solutions:

    (a) 0.1000M Propanoic acid($HC_3H_5O_2$, $K_a = 1.3 \times 10^{-5}$)

    (b) 0.1000M sodium propanoate ($Na\ C_3H_5O_2$)

    (c) 0.1000M $HC_3H_5O_2$ and 0.1000M $Na\ C_3H_5O_2$

(13) b) $K_a = 1.40\times10^{-3}$ then $K_b = \frac{K_w}{1.40\times10^{-3}} = \frac{1\times10^{-14}}{1.40\times10^{-3}} = 7.1428\times10^{-12}$

$M_{NaOH} = 0.01\,M$ $\quad M_1V_1 = M_2V_2$

$M_{HOOCCH_2Cl} = 0.01\,M$

$V_{HOOCCH_2Cl} = 0.05\,L$

$V_{NaOH} = 0.05\,L$ $\quad M_{NaOH}\cdot V_{NaOH} = 5\times10^{-4}\,mol_{NaOH}$

$V_{total} = 0.1\,L$

$$HOOCCH_2Cl + {}^{\ominus}OH \longrightarrow H_2O + {}^{\ominus}OOCCH_2Cl$$

I	5×10^{-4} mol	5×10^{-4} mol		$\emptyset$ mol
C	-5×10^{-4} mol	-5×10^{-4} mol		$+5\times10^{-4}$ mol
E	$\emptyset$ mol	$\emptyset$ mol		5×10^{-4} mol

$${}^{\ominus}OOCCH_2Cl = \frac{5\times10^{-4}\,mol}{0.1\,L} = 0.005\,M$$

Trying to find the $[OH^-]$

$$^{\ominus}OOCCH_2Cl + H_2O \rightleftharpoons OH^{\ominus} + HOOCCH_2Cl$$

I	0.005 M		$\emptyset$	$\emptyset$
C	$-x$		$+x$	$+x$
E	$0.005-x$		x	x

$$K_b = \frac{x^2}{0.005-x} \Rightarrow 7.1428\times10^{-12} = \frac{x^2}{0.005-x}$$

$$\approx 7.1428\times10^{-12} = \frac{x^2}{0.005}$$

$$\Rightarrow \sqrt{7.1428\times10^{-12}\cdot 0.005} = x$$

$$\Rightarrow x = 1.888814806\times10^{-7}$$

$$\approx 1.89\times10^{-7} = [OH^-]$$

$$pOH = -\log[OH^-]$$

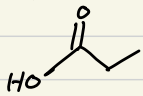
$$= 6.723580753$$

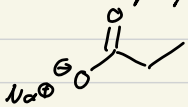
$$pH = 14 - pOH$$

$$= 7.276419247$$

$$\approx \boxed{7.28}$$

(15) Propanoic acid Sodium propanoate $K_a = 1.3 \times 10^{-5}$





0.1000 M 0.1000 M

$[HA]$ $[A^-]$

(a) Half-equivalence $[HA] = [A^-]$

So $pH = pK_a$

$pK_a = -\log(K_a)$

$= -\log(1.3 \times 10^{-5})$

$= 4.886056648$

$\approx \boxed{4.89}$

This is what we are looking for.

(15) b) $^{\ominus}C_3H_5O_2 + H_2O \rightleftharpoons OH^{\ominus} + HC_3H_5O_2 \quad K_a = 1.3\times10^{-5}$

I	0.1 M	∅	∅
C	$-x$	$+x$	$+x$
E	$0.1-x$	x	x

Remember that $K_w = K_a \times K_b$

$$\Rightarrow K_b = \frac{K_w}{K_a} = \frac{1.0\times10^{-14}}{1.3\times10^{-5}} = 7.692307692\times10^{-10}$$

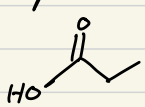
$$K_b = \frac{[OH^-][HB]}{[B^-]} \Rightarrow 7.69\times10^{-10} = \frac{x^2}{0.1-x}$$

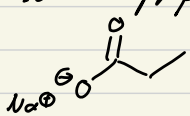
$$\Rightarrow x = \sqrt{0.1 \cdot 7.69\times10^{-10}} = 8.7705\times10^{-6}$$

$$pOH = -\log[OH^-]$$
$$= -\log(8.7705\times10^{-6})$$
$$= 5.056971676$$

$$pH = 14 - pOH \Rightarrow 14 - 5.056971676 = \boxed{8.94}$$

c) Propanoic acid — Sodium propanoate — $K_a = 1.3\times10^{-5}$





0.1000 M [HA] — 0.1000 M [A^-]

(a) Half-equivalence $[HA] = [A^-]$

So $pH = pK_a$

$$pK_a = -\log(K_a)$$
$$= -\log(1.3\times10^{-5})$$
$$= 4.886056648$$
$$\approx \boxed{4.89}$$

A ΔA B ΔB D ΔD

c) $[(0.642 \pm 0.002) \times (2.413 \pm 0.004)] - (0.501 \pm 0.002)$

$\frac{\Delta C}{C} = \frac{0.002}{0.642} + \frac{0.004}{2.413}$ $\frac{\Delta C}{C} = 0.004772\,9523$

$C = A \times B = 1.549146$ $\Delta C = 0.007394$

$\frac{\Delta E}{E} = \frac{\Delta C}{E} + \frac{\Delta D}{E}$ $E = C - D = 1.048146$

$\frac{\Delta E}{E} = \frac{0.007394 + 0.002}{1.048146}$

$= 0.008962\,4919$

$\approx 0.009 \times 100\% = \boxed{0.9\%}$

Absolute Error

$\Delta E = \frac{0.007394 + 0.002}{1.048146} \cdot E$

$= 0.009394 \approx \boxed{\pm 0.009}$

A ΔA B ΔB D ΔD

d) $[(12.635 \pm 0.005) / (5.967 \pm 0.003)] + (0.478 \pm 0.004)$

$\frac{\Delta C}{C} = \frac{0.005}{12.635} + \frac{0.003}{5.967}$ $\frac{\Delta C}{C} = 8.984\,91366 \times 10^{-4}$

$C = A/B = 2.117\,47947$ $\Delta C = 0.001\,902537$

$E = C + D = 2.595\,47947$

$\frac{\Delta E}{E} = \frac{\Delta C}{E} + \frac{\Delta D}{E}$

$\frac{\Delta E}{E} = \frac{0.001\,902537 + 0.004}{2.595\,47947}$

$= 0.002\,274\,1605$

$\approx 0.002 \times 100\% = \boxed{0.2\%}$

Absolute Error

$\Delta E = \frac{0.001\,902537 + 0.004}{2.595\,47947} \cdot 2.595\,47947$

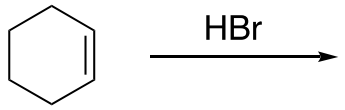
$= 0.005\,902537$

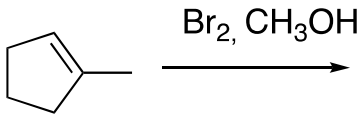
$\approx \boxed{\pm 0.006}$

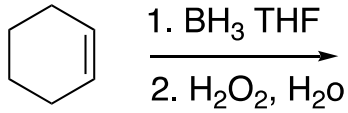
CHEM 30A: Organic Chemistry 1: Structure and Reactivity

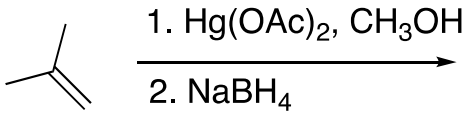
Week 9 worksheet

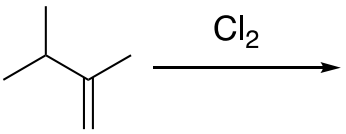
Draw the product of the following reactions:

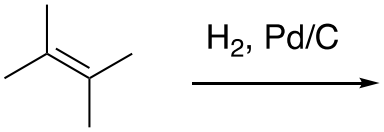


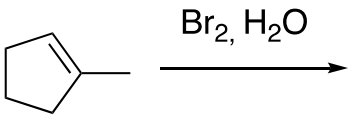


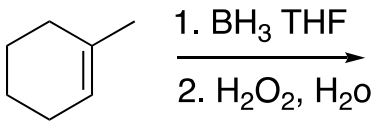


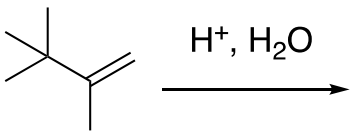


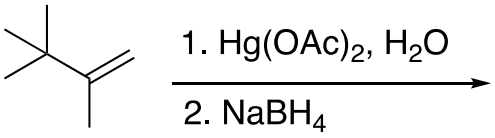




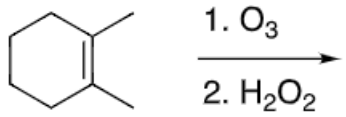


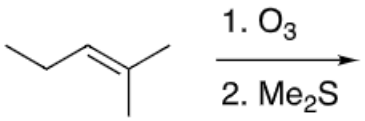


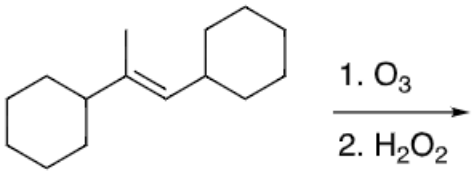




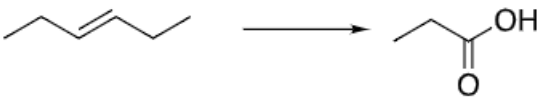
Draw the product of the following reactions:

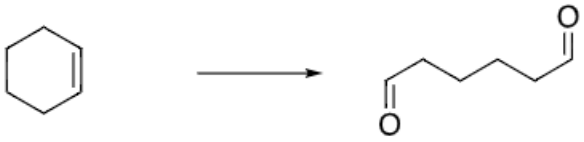






Give the appropriate reagents to complete the following transformations:





DocuSign Envelope ID: 967B63A1-9BCD-43C5-AED5-78D4234E7C7C

UCLA Information Technology Services

Information Technology Services
Wilshire Center, Suite 1100
Los Angeles, CA. 90095

November 7, 2023

Min Kyu Lee
9126 Langdon Ave. Apt. 105
North Hills, CA. 91343

Re: Welcome Letter

Min Kyu Lee:

As a follow-up to your employment offer letter, I am providing you with additional information related to your position. Your appointment will begin on November 13, 2023 and is anticipated to end on June 30, 2024. We will follow up shortly with additional details regarding your start date and departmental onboarding.

Please note that if not already completed, continued employment is contingent upon the successful completion and clearance of all employment requirements as stated in your employment offer letter.

As a condition of employment, you will be required to comply with the University of California Policy on Vaccination Programs, as may be amended or revised from time to time. Federal, state, or local public health directives may impose additional requirements. As updates are made to the Policy, they will be reflected in the UCLA Conditions of Employment.

We are looking forward to having you as part of our team. If you have questions, please contact me at 310 825-4651 or via email at aroper@it.ucla.edu .

Sincerely,

DocuSigned by:
Alan Roper
29DE5350D1E94E3...

Alan Roper
Academic Technology Manager, Bruin Learn Center of Excellence
UCLA Information Technology Services

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Min inspired and challenged students by pairing high expectations with consistent, individualized support. On the first day of class, he clearly stated that he would grade rigorously but fairly, setting a professional tone that initially felt intimidating but ultimately motivated students to engage more deeply with the material. Rather than lowering standards when students struggled, Min challenged us to rise to them.

He reframed unsuccessful experiments as opportunities for learning rather than failure. For example, when reactions did not proceed as expected, Min prompted students with guiding questions and asking us to identify possible sources of error and propose adjustments rather than providing immediate solutions. This approach encouraged critical thinking and scientific reasoning while helping my fellow labmates build confidence in their problem-solving abilities.

Min also inspired students by connecting coursework to life beyond the laboratory. Through informal conversations, he shared insights from his own experiences across multiple career paths, helping students see how organic chemistry skills translate to real-world applications. These moments transformed him from a grader into a mentor, inspiring students to think more intentionally about their academic and professional trajectories.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Min demonstrated exemplary student-centered and inclusive teaching through both his course structure and personalized instruction. Each week, he sent detailed lab newsletters recapping announcements, outlining weekly goals, and providing specific tips for pre-labs and post-labs. These newsletters required significant preparation yet ensured that all students—regardless of prior experience or confidence level—were aligned and supported.

Min also excelled at adapting instruction to individual student needs. During office hours, he tailored explanations based on students' learning styles and career goals. For instance, several of my lab mates were studying for the Dental Admission Test (DAT), and Min intentionally framed organic chemistry lab concepts using DAT-style logic and applications. This personalization helped students remain engaged while reinforcing foundational concepts for everyone.

In the lab, Min consistently promoted active learning. He allowed students time to troubleshoot independently and only intervened when necessary. When experiments repeatedly failed, he came to the lab hood and personally demonstrated proper apparatus setup, modeling best practices while preserving student autonomy. He further supported learning by recording and sharing video lessons for challenging topics, enabling students to review material at their own pace.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA, LOS ANGELES **UCLA**

BERKELEY • DAVIS • IRVINE • LOS ANGELES • RIVERSIDE • SAN DIEGO • SAN FRANCISCO SANTA BARBARA • SANTA CRUZ

DEPARTMENT OF CHEMISTRY AND BIOCHEMISTRY
P.O. Box 951569
607 Charles E. Young Drive, East
LOS ANGELES, CALIFORNIA 90095-1569
PHONE: (310) 206-2203
FAX: (310) 206-4038
E-MAIL: mhenary@g.ucla.edu

January 30, 2026

Distinguished Teaching Award – Supporting Letters
Teaching & Learning Center

To Whom It May Concern:

I would like to nominate Min Kyu Lee for the Distinguished Teaching Award this year. Min was one of my students in my general and organic chemistry Lab courses; he has done a good job. Min worked efficiently throughout the experiment with patience and precision. He observed the experiment and recorded data carefully and his lab notes were descriptive and specific. He worked independently and obtained accurate results.

Beyond my experience with Min as his teacher, he was also working for me as one of my TA's for over three years in which, he taught Chem 14BL, Chem 14CL and Chem 30AL. In all of these courses he did an excellent job. This winter quarter he is currently an Instrumentation TA for my Chem 14CL class. To be qualifying for a teaching assistant, you should be knowledgeable about the subject and be willing to help students whenever they need help. Min was one of my best TA.

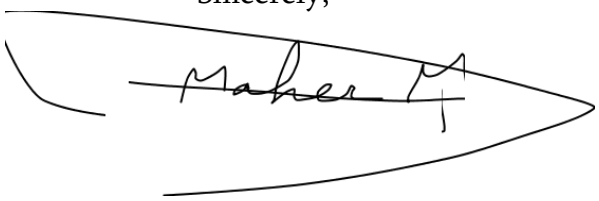
Min's responsibilities were as follows: 1) teaching general chemistry laboratories 2) grading exams and laboratory notebooks and 3) holding office hours. In all of these responsibilities, Min has done an outstanding job.

Min is doing a great job here at UCLA in all his responsibilities as a teaching assistant. In all my dealing with him, I have always found him to be well organized and professional.

He is always on time, comes to the lab well prepared. It is easy to have Min as a colleague; he serves the teaching mission of the university well. I am strongly recommending him to be admitted to the MACA program in our department.

I truly believe that Min Kyu Lee will deserve to be rewarded and recognized by the Academic Senate. If you have any question(s) please, feel free to contact me.

Sincerely,



Maher M. Henary, Ph.D.
Instructional Laboratory Support Director
& Lecturer in Chemistry